

Sharp AM-400

The Sharp AM-400 is a 4-in-1 solution for SoHos and SMBs. It provides copying, faxing, printing and scanning functionalities in a single package. What makes this multifunctional device different from the rest in this comparison test is the fact that it is based on the copier engine.

Being copier-based, it comes with not just a single toner cartridge, but also a drum. The advantage of having a separate toner and drum is that if one of them is exhausted, you need to replace only that one, so overall running cost is reduced as compared to printer-based solutions, where the toner has to be discarded and replaced. In addition to this, the duty cycle and print speeds are also very high, making for a lower cost per page. On the downside, copier-based MFDs are somewhat more expensive than their printer-based counterparts.

Coming back to the Sharp AM-400, it has an optical print and scan resolution of 600 x 600 dpi, which is just fine for the small business segment, where one does not need a very high degree of image accuracy in scanning. The input



tray accommodates 250 sheets; it is augmented by a 50-sheet capacity bypass feed. The output tray is also very large—it holds 250 sheets.

The drum duty cycle is 20,000, whereas the toner duty cycle is 3,000.

The flatbed and sheet-fed 24-bit colour scanner can scan papers of up to Legal size. The ADF tray, with a 20-sheet capacity, is useful to automatically scan a stack of documents.

The scanner features the TWAIN as well as the WIA interfaces. The AM-400 supports Super G3 high-speed fax at 33.6

kbps. The copier can reduce and enlarge up to 99 copies in continuous mode.

TWAIN is an interface that was designed to provide a universal public standard to link applications and image acquisition devices such as cameras, scanners and the like.

The print speed of this MFD was found to be a bit slower than that of the others in our test, but print quality was on par with the best. The scanner was faster than the others we tested. Copying was slow, with the first copy of the warmed-up device taking 20 seconds.

The build quality of the AM-400 is rugged, but the removable output paper tray cannot be firmly anchored into the MFD.

The device can connect to the PC via USB 2.0 as well as the parallel port interfaces. It weighs just 12.7 kg, and is 47.5 cm wide and 42 cm deep, which is pretty small for a copier-based MFD. Power consumption is rated at 870 W.

We reckon the Sharp AM-400 is a good buy for small and medium businesses. The price of Rs. 33,500 also seems to be justified.

images to your PC—you can also manipulate the images before transferring them.

Copying

Since we only tested mono MFDs, copying, naturally, was limited to greyscale. All the MFDs had similar features—standalone copying, reduce and enlarge, and up to 99 copies in multiple copying mode. 99 copies is normally more than enough for a SoHo.

Facsimile

General Considerations

The Samsung SF-565P is the only model to sport a handset. This makes it a telefax—a telephone-cum-fax, so you can make telephone calls using the same machine. The Canon MF 3110 and the Samsung SCX-4100 do not have a fax unit inbuilt.

Memory

The 4 MB of fax memory on the Lexmark X215 makes it possible to receive and store a larger number of fax messages when the machine runs out of paper. Broadcasting and Scheduled Faxing are standard on all the MFDs in this test. Broadcasting allows you to send a fax to a group of numbers in the phonebook memory. Scheduled Faxing allows you to send a fax at a specified time.

Miscellaneous Features

Physical Considerations

Weighing in at 13.6 kg and measuring 47 x 41.9 x 43.2 cm, the Lexmark X215 has the largest dimensions while also being the heav-



Lexmark X215

iest. The Samsung SF-565P is the lightest and also the most compact amongst the MFDs with the fax feature. The SF-565P has a compact and sleek appearance, and is well suited for small offices due to its considerably smaller footprint. We found the overall build quality of the Lexmark X215 to be very rugged; the build quality of the Samsung SCX-4521F and Xerox PE220, too, is commendable.

Interface And Memory

Barring the Canon MF 3110, which features only the USB 2.0 interface—all the other MFDs in this test have the USB 2.0 as well as the parallel interfaces.